

November 2024

CoARA Action Plan of AQuAS

2024-2027

The Agency for Health Quality and Assessment of Catalonia (AQuAS) is a public entity of the Catalan Health Ministry of the Government of Catalonia acting for public policies. Its mission is to generate relevant knowledge by evaluating and analysing data for decision-making in order to improve the health of citizens and the sustainability of the Catalan Health Care System. AQuAS is a founding member of the International Network of Agencies of Health Technology Assessment (INAHTA) and the International School on Research Impact Assessment (ISRIA), it is a corporate member of Health Technology Assessment International (HTAi), of the CI-BER group (Networked Biomedical Research Centers) in Epidemiology and Public Health, and of REDISSEC (Spanish Research Network on Health Services in Chronic Diseases), and of RICAPPS (Research Network in Chronicity, Primary Care and Health Promotion), as well as an associated unit of the INGENIO (CSIC-UPV) research centre. AQuAS was awarded with the Josep Trueta's Medal for its health merits by the Government of Catalonia.

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Introduction

The Agency for Health Quality and Assessment of Catalonia (AQuAS) is a public agency of the Department of Health of the Catalan Government. AQuAS aims to generate relevant knowledge to enhance the quality, safety, and sustainability of Catalonia's health system, and to support decision-making for citizens, health professionals, managers, and health planning authorities.

Biomedical, clinical, and health services research play an important role in transforming the health system. One of AQuAS's main tasks is to promote impactful health research by providing tools for evaluating, analysing, anticipating outcomes, informing decisions in policy and scientific planning.

The Research Lab of AQuAS is responsible for the evaluation of research programmes, research centres and research ecosystems. Its focus is on health research and biomedicine, although most of the work being done has been “exported” and adapted to other disciplines.

In December 2022, AQuAS formally signed the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment and joined the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA), under the leadership of the Research Lab but with the subsequent approval from its executive direction. This endorsement involves the formulation of an action plan for the progressive reform of internal research assessment systems, a commitment to be completed within five years (December 2027).

Moreover, in April 2023, AQuAS supported the creation of the CoARA Spanish National Chapter, and is committed to participate actively in its activities.

This document defines the **CoARA action plan 2024-27 for AQuAs**. This action plan is crafted with the objective of integrating CoARA commitments into as many AQuAS research assessment policies and practices as possible.

This first version of the action plan has been drafted by the Research Lab of AQuAS and is a living document that will be updated regularly. It outlines what AQuAS is currently doing regarding the CoARA commitments, as well as its objectives and plans for 2024-2027.

AQuAS' Research Evaluation Context

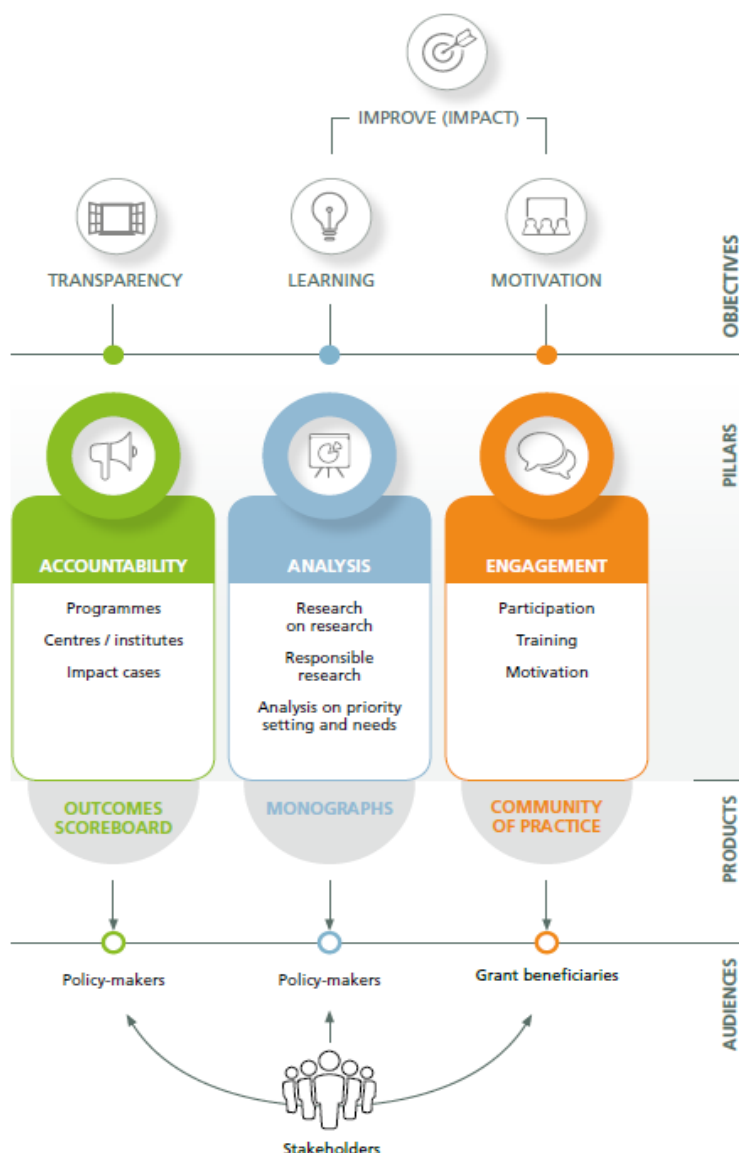
AQuAS is an organization with a historical commitment for exploring the principles of responsible research assessment, aiming to ensure research excellence and social research impact through its evaluation practices. AQuAS believes that impactful research drives positive transformation across the healthcare ecosystem.

Recognizing the need for a global dialogue on effective ways to carry research impact assessment, AQuAS co-founded [the International School on Research Impact Assessment \(ISRIA\)](#) in 2013. This initiative has equipped over 450 professionals from 34 countries with the skills to assess the impact of research investments, fostering a global dialogue on how research can best serve society.

In 2018, AQuAS developed the Health Research Evaluation Framework (SARIS framework) that sets the main axis to evaluate in a responsible way the research promoted and funded by the Department of Health of the Catalan Government with the objective to adopt an assessment that while ensuring excellence, contributes to optimize impact of research by adopting an approach of continuous learning and improvement.

Guided by the axis of the SARIS framework, AQuAS's evaluations efforts focus on accountability, comprehensive analysis, and stakeholder engagement. These evaluations encompass research calls, performance of research institutes in health and biomedical research co-participated by the Catalan Government and broader aspects of the Catalan health and biomedical research ecosystem (ex: women leadership in health research). AQuAS assessments goes beyond a traditional evaluation metrics to a model that integrates principles of responsible research assessment and co-responsibility for generating research impact. It aligns with global initiatives like the CoARA coalition, DORA Declaration, Leiden Manifesto, ISRIA Statement or the UNESCO definition of Open Science, advocating for open, diverse, and impactful scientific evaluation.

Figure 1: The SARIS Framework (AQuAS, 2018)

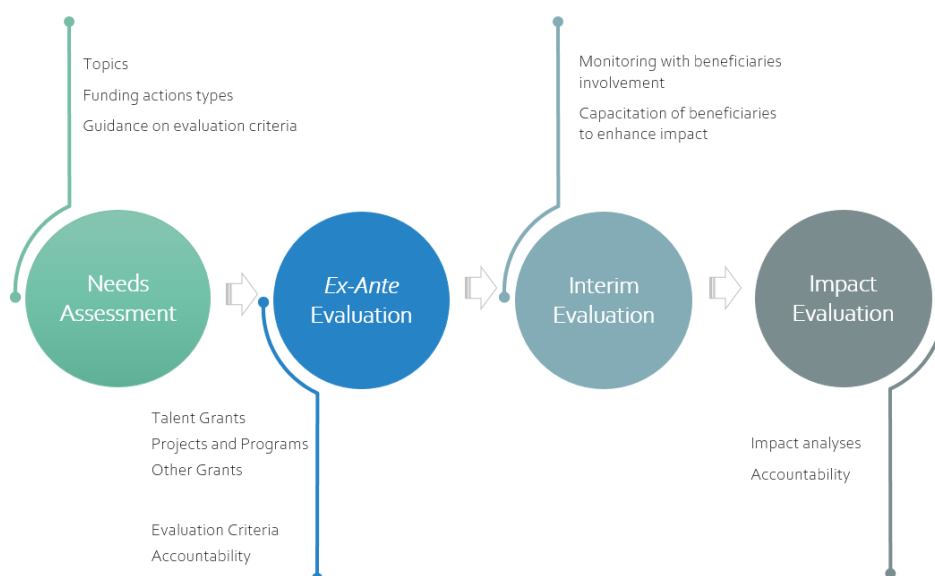


AQuAS is responsible for various research assessment activities, each with its own processes and tools:

- **Evaluation of health research calls.** AQuAS evaluates [various competitive calls](#) in health research commissioned by different funders. These calls have diverse objectives and beneficiaries, ranging from funding individuals, research groups, projects, or institutions. The evaluation process starts with a **needs assessment** to help funders to shape the design of these calls. The **ex-ante evaluation** process involves allocating resources competitively based on predefined criteria and methods co-created with the funding agencies. During **interim evaluation**, AQuAS supports beneficiaries in achieving objectives beyond mere compliance monitoring. This approach moves away from “*fund and forget*” model and fosters shared responsibility. AQuAS periodically organizes activities designed to build the capacity of the grant beneficiaries to enabling the research achieve a greater

impact. At the end of the evaluation cycle, an impact evaluation is performed. **Impact evaluation** includes accountability and analysis to demonstrate citizens and other stakeholders the social value of funding health research. The evaluation timelines align with program designs, focusing on either short-term outcomes or longer-term impacts. With this cycle, AQuAS ensures that research quality is guaranteed while maximizing its impact on the healthcare system and returning scientific knowledge to society.

Figure 2: Stages of AQuAS evaluation process for Research Calls



- **Evaluation of health research centres.** Since 2014, AQuAS has published every two-years indicators of research process achieved by health and biomedical research centres in Catalonia, including the hospital-based research institutes. The objective is to inform policy-makers about research investments, enable comparisons and benchmarking of results, identify opportunities for improvement, and help the government make evidence-based policy decisions. This exercise ensures transparency and accountability in the use of R&D resources in the Catalan health system.
- **Evaluation of the sex/gender perspective and gender equality.** [The Hypathia Community of Practice \(Hypathia CoP\)](#) is a community of practice of research centres in Catalonia coordinated by AQuAS focused **on advancing gender equality in health research**. Founded on 2021, it promotes mutual learning and knowledge exchange through activities like best practice sessions, workshops, and webinars. The community adheres to the [Hypathia of Alexandria Charter](#), which emphasizes renovating policies, integrating gender perspectives in research, fostering women's career advancement, and removing unconscious biases. Key initiatives include developing [a toolkit for incorporating sex and gender perspectives in research](#), training on implicit bias, creating [inclusive language](#)

[guidelines](#), addressing resistances to structural change, and promoting women's advancement and leadership. Additionally, the Hypathia CoP has organized Gender Summits to stimulate progress through self-assessment and reflection.

- **Research on research to support health research planning.** The SARIS monographs provide critical insights into current health research issues, offering analysis for decision-makers, professionals, and the public. These monographs serve as a reflection tool, guiding evidence-based decisions in science policy. They are organized into three series: *Responsible Research*, which addresses topics like gender equality and research engagement; *Research that Transforms*, showcasing successful research cases with societal impact; and *Research Priorities*, focusing on the analysis of research portfolios. These publications enable continuous improvement in research planning and emphasize the transformative power of well-targeted research. Here is a table summarizing the SARIS monographs:

Table 1: SARIS monographs

No	Title	Year	Series
9	The value of promoting nursing research: 30 impact cases from PERIS 2017-2021	2024	Research that transforms
8	Actions to raise awareness about gender perspective in research content	2023	Responsible research. Gender
7	Women's advancement and leadership in the biomedical research centers of Catalonia ii	2020	Responsible research. Gender
6	Women's advancement and leadership in the biomedical research centers of Catalonia	2020	Responsible research. Gender
5	Exploratory study of the impact of research at the Vall d'Hebron university hospital	2019	Research that transforms
4	How did the first nursing experience: impact analysis of PERIS 2017 nursing research call	2018	Research that transforms
3	Participation in research: why and how.	2019	Responsible research. Engagement
2	Are we ready for citizen participation in health research?	2018	Responsible research. Engagement
1	How to measure the participation in health research of the actors of the system? literature review	2018	Responsible research. Engagement

- **Building capacities, discussion and community within the Catalan research ecosystem.** [Transformative Science Tuesdays](#) is a bi-monthly series of sessions launched in October 2023 through a collaboration between AQuAS, INGENIO (CSIC-UPV), and CWTS: It brings together research managers, policymakers, researchers, and other

stakeholders to discuss topics such as research assessment reform, open science, and research impact, encouraging diverse perspectives and active engagement. Each session features diverse speakers and active participant engagement, promoting mutual learning and reflection. Another key initiative are the SARIS sessions, they provide training across the research calls lifecycle, focusing on impact literacy and open science principles like gender equality, open access, and research impact. Using a formative evaluation model, they offer real-time impact evaluation tools to encourage forward-looking actions and shared responsibility in maximizing research impact. Together, these initiatives foster dialogue among researchers, share best practices, and strengthen the research ecosystem in Catalonia by promoting critical reflections on inclusive and impactful research practices.

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Action Plan 2024-2027

AQuAS is embedding CoARA commitments into its research assessment policies and procedures. Over the past years, AQuAS has been already working on improving its research assessment procedures towards a responsible research assessment, aligning our work with the principles of Open Science, DORA or the Leiden Manifesto that have influenced us significantly.

The CoARA Action Plan 2024-2027 is structured around five strategic action lines that guide the implementation in AQuAS of CoARA commitments. These actions aim to foster a more inclusive, responsible, and impactful research assessment ecosystem within Catalonia's health research landscape:

- 1. Expanding evaluation criteria and methodologies (L1).** This line focuses on refining AQuAS's assessment frameworks to recognize a broader array of research contributions and career trajectories, moving beyond traditional metrics and adopting qualitative indicators to provide a more holistic evaluation of research and research impact.
- 2. Stakeholder training and support (L2).** AQuAS is committed to building the capacities of researchers, reviewers, and other research stakeholders by offering training and guidance that emphasize qualitative assessment approaches and the principles of responsible research evaluation and open science.
- 3. Dissemination, knowledge exchange and community building (L3).** This action line encompass active engagement with local, national, and international peers, including CoARA's community. It involves organizing sessions in AQuAS context to discuss advancements and best practices in research assessment as well as building connections with other entities to exchange experiences and promote mutual learning.
- 4. Promoting cultural and institutional change (L4).** AQuAS aims to participate in discussions to promote the cultural shift within the research community by engaging stakeholders in strategic discussions. It will also use internal resources like SARIS monographs to highlight responsible research assessment and advocate for systemic change.
- 5. Evaluation, and continuous improvement (L5).** This line ensures ongoing progress through evidence-based evaluation of implemented actions, regular reviews of the action plan, and open channels for feedback to maintain alignment with best practices and evolving needs.

Strategic Line	Current Achievements (September 2024)	Action Description	CoARA Commitment
L1: Expanding Evaluation Criteria and Methodologies	<i>Research calls:</i> AQuAS does not use publication-based quantitative metrics as the central element to evaluate the scientific quality of call applications. Instead, we use a qualitative peer-review approach as the central element of our review processes. All assessment processes of research calls are based on a two-step methodology. First, there is a per-review remote evaluation (with an assessment toolkit) and second there is a panel discussion. We have established processes to ensure a balanced composition of peer-reviewer panels, considering diverse skills, experience, knowledge across disciplines, age and gender representation. For a selected group of talent calls, the standardized CVN^a is no longer required. Instead, the application form includes sections where applicants can provide a narrative description of their career trajectories, offering a more comprehensive view beyond quantitative indicators. Additionally, in certain assessments, applicants have the option to submit both their standardized CVN and a narrative description of their scientific trajectories.	<i>Research Calls:</i> Keep exploring opportunities to recognize a broader range of research contributions (e.g., interdisciplinary work, community engagement, impact beyond academia...) research calls, with a focus on iterative process improvement and continue exploring narrative CVs where relevant. Engage reviewers and research beneficiaries in a feedback loop of 'learning and improving' cycles to refine processes based on the outcomes of each call.	1. Recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
	<i>Research centres:</i> AQuAS abandoned the journal impact factor (JIF) and the H-index as metrics for the scientific contributions of the centres many years ago. To characterise research centres AQuAS uses quantitative indicators related to publications, funding, research transfer (such as patents, spin-offs, clinical trials, or clinical practice guidelines), and human resources, which also includes gender equity data.	Promote the benefits of involving health professionals, like nurses and primary care physicians, in research by conducting research impact assessment exercises that demonstrate how their research contributes to enhancing and transforming the healthcare system, broadening the scope of evaluation methodologies to include diverse research profiles.	
		<i>Research Centres:</i> Explore the feasibility of introducing qualitative indicators and the responsible use of quantitative indicators, to more comprehensively characterize their research contributions.	2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
L2: Stakeholder Training and Support	We have presented CoARA to our decision-makers to raise awareness about changes in the research system, in order to improve future calls. We have conducted online sessions with call beneficiaries during project implementation to support gender perspective in research and FAIR data practices.	Develop and disseminate examples for researchers and potential grantees, drawing on our impact studies and other international impact studies, to illustrate diverse research contributions, career trajectories, outputs, outcomes, and impacts.	1. Recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
		Provide training sessions to call beneficiaries during project implementation on impact roadmaps to maximize the effectiveness of research impact grants, while fostering shared	

^a The [CVN](#) is a digital standardized and unique CV for spanish researchers promoted by la Fundación Española para la Ciencia y la Tecnología

Strategic Line	Current Achievements (September 2024)	Action Description	CoARA Commitment
	We have conducted sessions with all reviewers of our calls aiming to improve qualitative assessments and responsible methods, reducing peer-review bias, the balanced use of quantitative metrics or integrating gender perspectives to enhance responsible evaluation culture.	responsibility in addressing current social needs. Additionally, support the development of a network and community among grantees to encourage collaboration and knowledge exchange.	
		Develop internal capacity to deliver training sessions to applicants on how to craft narrative CVs that facilitate a more qualitative evaluation process, emphasizing the more diverse set of research contributions and career paths.	2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
		Provide guidance sessions and support to remote reviewers and panellists for adapting to a high quality qualitative assessment approach. Offer guidelines to evaluators tailored to the specific content and objectives of each call, emphasizing bias mitigation, responsible evaluation practices, and AQuAS's vision on research evaluation. These resources will be made available on the AQuAS website alongside other materials related to research assessment reform and the CoARA agenda.	7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
L3: Dissemination, knowledge exchange and community building	We promoted CoARA principles internally in the whole organisation of AQuAS. We conducted an internal session for staff to ensure a thorough understanding of CoARA principles. We engaged the AQuAS executive committee in discussions to integrate CoARA principles into our policies and procedures. We have fostered reflection on the advancement on research assessment practices through a session in autumn 2023 as part of the Transformative Science Tuesdays. This community debate, co-organized by AQuAS, shares content and best practices, encouraging critical thinking on science and research, with active participation from the research community.	Participate in the Spanish National Chapter of CoARA activities, to exchange practices and experiences for mutual learning.	8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition
		Explore opportunities to join CoARA working groups to deepen engagement and exchange practices.	
		Explore other alliances beyond CoARA members, fostering exchange and mutual learning.	

Strategic Line	Current Achievements (September 2024)	Action Description	CoARA Commitment
		Promote CoARA principles advancement by hosting a follow-up session of Transformative Science Tuesdays, inviting all entities in Catalonia that have published a CoARA action plan, as well as other signatories and non-signatories, to collectively review progress and discuss joint advancements in research assessment practices.	
L4: Promoting cultural and institutional change	We have actively supported the Catalan Government in advancing research impact assessment at systemic level, and promoting gender equality in Catalan research. Our contributions also include strategic policy development through advisory roles and collaborative engagement with key stakeholders.	Raise awareness towards responsible assessment by using our SARIS monographs and sessions and highlight the social impact of research within the Catalan research ecosystem.	7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
		Keep actively engaging with relevant decision-making stakeholders, to develop and promote policies that drive cultural change. This includes enhancing impact research culture through systemic research impact assessment exercises, training and capacity building initiatives.	
		Support systemic change by advocating for gender equity in research leadership and research practices through the actions of the Hypathia CoP .	1. Recognize the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research
		Ensure that a member of the Research Lab is actively involved in CoARA activities and in the implementation of the current Action Plan with a reasonable allocation of time to these tasks.	5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to
		Allocate necessary resources to support the implementation of changes, including the creation of guidance documents, delivery of stakeholder training, and organization of meetings and activities that foster cultural and organizational shifts in research assessment.	

Strategic Line	Current Achievements (September 2024)	Action Description	CoARA Commitment
L5: Evaluation, and continuous improvement		Implement an annual review and revision process for the Action Plan to ensure it remains current and effective. AQuAs will regularly communicate updates on the implementation of CoARA commitments through reports and other public channels.	9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments

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